

give it a slight edge, as the Core 2 Duo X6800 runs at 2992 MHz instead of 2933 MHz.

A surprise was in store when the MSI P35 Diamond and P35 Platinum came up with very good CPU performance in our video encoding test, in which a difference of one second is huge—especially when you consider the fact that all speeds and voltages were kept identical.

Verdict

We're impressed by the sheer performance provided by ASUS' P5K Premium. The fact that it's a superb looker and comes with an excellent bundle of connectors and add-ons just amplifies our decision to award a *Digit Best Buy Gold* to this excellent product.

Gigabyte's GA-P35-DS3R stuck close to the ASUS P5K3 Deluxe (a DDR3-based board) throughout the tests and we're awarding these two a joint *Digit Best Buy Silver*.

Other boards that impress on the performance front are the P5K Deluxe and Blitz Formula from ASUS, Abit's IP-35 Pro Off Limits and Gigabyte's GA-P35-DQ6.

If you're looking for an enthusiast solution that overclocks well and simplifies the process, select any of the ASUS boards we've mentioned.

If you want something a little cheaper, take a look at Abit's IP-35 Pro Off Limits, Gigabyte's GA-P35DS3R or MSI's P35 Platinum.

If you're looking for value we suggest either MSI's P35 Neo or Abit's IP-35 E Off Limits priced at Rs 6,600 and 8,500 respectively.

We suggest avoiding the cheaper offerings—unless you have an absolute shoestring budget and must have a P35 chipset based board.

NVIDIA 680I/680I LT/650I SLI AND 650I ULTRA-BASED MOTHERBOARDS

NVIDIA's 680i has been around for a while, but it was a path breaking chipset when launched, and thanks to some future-proofing on

NVIDIA's part, it still has the goods to take on the P35-based boards. The high-end 680i boards are the exclusive domain of the lightning fast Core 2 Duo processors from Intel, so you'll see no AMD based solutions here.

The 680i LT is a lower version of the 680i core logic, and manages to do without faster memory profiles—the 680i is optimised for 1200 MHz SLI-ready memory. These platforms support SLI and a full 16 PCI Express lanes to each graphics card.



ASUS Striker Extreme
The SLI demon

The 650 SLI offers 8 lanes to each card, while the 650 Ultra is a single PCI Express.

The 6xx family from NVIDIA also has one very important feature for overclockers—they allow for overclocking independent of memory dividers. This means you no longer have to bother with maintaining memory to FSB ratios while overclocking like you have to with Intel boards. This is a boon for those who have cheaper RAM but want to overclock their machines. On Intel boards, as the FSB speed is bumped up, your memory also has to match up to maintain a pre-defined ratio—typically 2 : 1 or 3 : 1. For example, for an FSB of 266 MHz your memory should be capable of running at 800 MHz (266 x 3) if the memory divider is set at 3.

Besides this, the 680i/LT allows overclockers to set memory reference voltages, as well as set reference voltages for the Northbridge and Southbridge as well as overvolt them (which most chipsets provide an option for).

Features

ASUS' P5N32-E SLI had perhaps one of the best

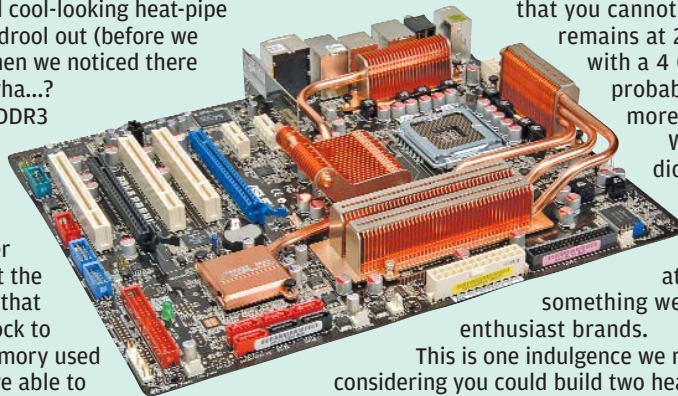
ASUS P5K3 Premium: Is it worth the money?

Every once in a while, a product comes along that makes us go "Ooh, let's give this one a special box, shall we?" Why the ASUS P5K3 Premium? Well, for one, it's four times as expensive (Rs 70,000) as most of its other (already expensive) siblings! For another, it's got this ultra-large and cool-looking heat-pipe solution that immediately gets the drool out (before we saw the price tag of course)! And then we noticed there were no memory banks for RAM...wha...?

This board comes with 2 GB of DDR3 memory integrated—and fast memory at that (1333 MHz). The fact that the memory is integrated, and very obviously matched to the board means that it performs better than external DDR3 RAM running at the same speed. ASUS also guarantees that this integrated memory will overclock to 1,500 MHz. It's evident that the memory used is top-class, simply because we were able to set very tight timings (1333 MHz at 7-6-6-17 at 1.7 volts), which is pretty incredible considering our 1066 MHz

DDR3 ran at 7-7-7-24!

We got an overall PC Mark score of 8,535 and a memory score of 6,112, and at the above mentioned timings we got 6329—a very good showing. The only demerit is that you cannot upgrade memory, which remains at 2 GB. If ASUS had come out with a 4 GB variant the board would probably cost close to a lakh, if not more...



We honestly believe ASUS didn't really expect any takers for such an expensive board. Instead, it's more like a statement—"Look at what we can do!"—

something we've come to expect from enthusiast brands.

This is one indulgence we recommend you miss—considering you could build two healthy PCs for the price of this board. If you're insanely rich (or just insane) then you'd probably discount this bit of advice.